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Effects of Cyberbullying and How it Can be Prevented

Technology is available almost everywhere now. It made everything easier, but it has just as many demerits as its merits. One of the most concerning problems faced by people because of technology these days is cyberbullying. According to UNICEF, “Cyberbullying is bullying with the use of digital technologies. It can take place on social media, messaging platforms, gaming platforms and mobile phones. It is repeated behavior, aimed at scaring, angering, or shaming those who are targeted” (Cyberbullying). Although bullying and the effect on victims are the same for cyberbullying and traditional bullying (face-to-face), there are some differences, “Cyberbullying differs from traditional forms of bullying in that the identity of the perpetrator is often hidden from the victim by creating a false identity (often by means of a false email account and social networking profile). According to Patchin and Hinduja, only 31% of cyberbullying victims knew the perpetrator, whilst 84% of perpetrators knew their victim” (Dodds). One more difference according to ICDL Arabia is, “cyberbullying can happen anywhere. As long as someone has access to the Internet, a bully can harass someone, and a victim can find an offensive comment about them” (5Differences).

There are many reports of cyberbullying. According to cyberbullying statistics, “About half of young people have experienced some form of cyber bullying, and 10 to 20 percent experience it regularly” (Cyber Bullying Statistics). Another study showed that “About 37% of young people between the ages of 12 and 17 have been bullied online. 30%

have had it happen more than once” (11 facts). There are many platforms where people get bullied. According to Sam Cook, a data journalist, writing for Comapritech, “Around 79 percent of children who use YouTube have experienced cyberbullying, which leads to stressful interactions on the video platform. Meanwhile, around 50 percent of young people on Facebook experience cyberbullying. That’s still far too high, but lower than the 64 percent of victims on TikTok and 69 percent on Snapchat” (Cook). There are many surveys that showed that cyberbullying is done even while playing online, “In one survey, 79% of gamers reported that they had been cyberbullied while playing online” (Cook).

Victims of cyberbullying are mainly females and people belonging to the LGBTQ+ community (Cook). “Girls are more likely to be victims of cybercrime (except for those bullied within the last 30 days), while boys are more likely to be cyberbullies” (Cook) and, “Over 28.1% of LGBTQ teens were cyberbullied in 2019, compared to 14.1% of their heterosexual peers” (Cook). Adults are also victims of cyberbullying “According to PEW research from 2021, over 40% of adults have experienced cyberbullying and harassment online” (Cook).

Even celebrities can’t escape from being cyberbullied. Selena Gomez, a famous singer, expressed her concerns about being bullied online, “Imagine all the insecurities that you already feel about yourself and having someone write a paragraph pointing out every little thing, even if it’s just physical” (7 stars). Another South Korean star committed suicide because of cyberbullying, “Sulli, a South Korean singer and actor who took her own life in 2019, was another victim of cyberbullying” (Kashyap).

The extent to which cyberbullying can affect a person’s life is evident through many stories of victims. A 13-year-old girl from California said, “It feels like you could die inside” (Share). A parent of a 16-year-old boy from Minnesota expresses concern about her son,

My sixteen-year-old son was cyber bullied on Facebook over a period of 8 hours. The event was so traumatic it caused my son to have an acute psychotic break and to be hospitalized in an adolescent psychiatric ward for almost a month. He is changed forever and will never be the same mentally. Internet bullying can hurt and affect people and kids need to know this. These kids are not being punished in any way and think the incident is funny! We know it is life changing (Share).

There are several stories, such as the ones mentioned above, that indicate the effects of cyberbullying on teens. Cyberbullying has effects on students' academic performance,

Another study in 2019 in SAJIM said that students were negatively affected both emotionally and academically by cyberbullying—to the extent that some thought of suicide. About 41 percent of the victims confirmed that they became less active in class, 24 percent confirmed that their school performance had dropped, and 35 percent had repeated a grade since becoming targets of online bullying (Scheff).

An article written by Catherine Kolonko and reviewed by Lori Lawrenz, a clinical psychologist, states that, by most cyberbullying cases go unreported because “many people who experience cyberbullying may keep quiet out of embarrassment, fear, or shame” (Kolonko). Mental health issues due to cyberbullying are not uncommon. There are high chances of an increase in depression, anxiety, loneliness, suicidal ideation, low self-esteem, social isolation, substance use, and sadness for victims of cyberbullying (Kolonko). In some instances, cyberbullying can result in the death of the person “In 2010, Rutgers University freshman Tyler Clementi jumped to his death from the George Washington Bridge after he

learned that his roommate and a friend had secretly recorded an intimate encounter he had with another man (and posted about it online)” (Negative).

Cyberbullying not only affects victims but also bullies, “StopBullying.gov notes that perpetrators are more likely to: Get into fights, vandalize property, drop out of school, engage in early sexual activity, abuse alcohol and other drugs in adolescence and adulthood, have criminal convictions and traffic citations as adults, be abusive toward their intimate partners, spouses, or children as adults” (Negative).

Although cyberbullying cannot be completely eradicated, there are several methods that can help to lessen it and assist victims of cyberbullying. Eliminating the risk at first before it becomes big is important. There are some steps that need to be taken first if someone ever felt like they are being cyberbullied. It is best not to take chances here because cyberbullying can quickly escalate if proper actions are not taken. Quinn, a digital marketing manager, suggested a few ways a person can respond to being cyberbullied. “One of the first ways is to ignore them. Some people are trying to get a reaction out of the person they are bullying, and if they see that you are not feeding into it or don’t care to respond, they may stop doing it” (Quinn). Ignoring the person starts by blocking the person. “Use available tech tools. Most social media apps and services allow you to block the person. Whether the harassment’s in an app, texting, comments or tagged photos, do yourself a favor and block the person. You can also report the problem to the service” (Tips).

In case blocking or ignoring doesn’t work, Nelson, a police sergeant, says that it is helpful to save the evidence. “Screenshot or save every email, text, instant message, social-media post, and any other evidence of cyberbullying that you come across. Record the time and date that each message was sent. If you can’t screenshot the offensive messages, you can copy/paste them and save the text on your hard drive” (Nelson). This evidence can be shown

to an authority figure to show proof that one is being bullied. These are the most basic steps that might help but if this doesn't stop the bullying it is better to get help from someone reliable.

The major role in helping teens get over cyberbullying is played by parents or someone close to them. A sixteen-year-old girl from Illinois states how notifying her parents helped her get rid of the bully, "My parents talked with the parents of the other student. My parents encouraged me to block the student and to change my screen name and passwords. I think the fact that my parents called the other student's parents and went right to the source helped" (Patchin). In a survey conducted by Cyberbullying Research Center most of the cyberbullied students said that telling their parents helped, "When asked to tell us what worked to stop cyberbullying, almost 17% of respondents said telling their parent(s) was helpful" (Patchin).

To provide help parents need to observe changes in the behavior of children. There are certain signs such as difficulty sleeping, nightmares, skipping school, feeling helpless, loss of self-esteem, stomach-aches, headaches, and emotional symptoms such as anxiety, embarrassment, frustration, and being unable to talk about their feelings that indicate that their child is being bullied (Kolonko).

Teachers and schools also play an important role in reducing cyberbullying. Schools need to educate students about cyberbullying and how to take effective measures if they face it. Teachers also need to educate themselves about cyberbullying. Dr. Patricia Fioriello says, "In addition to better education, a key tool in combating cyberbullying is parental and teacher involvement. First and foremost, they need to educate themselves about cyberbullying and teach their children and students about what cyberbullying is, why it is wrong, and how to handle it when they or someone else is a victim of cyberbullying" (Fioriello).

Awareness needs to be created about the consequences of cyberbullying and the laws that can help victims because “A lot of people also dismiss cyberbullying as minor and think it is just a kid saying insulting things towards one another. Even beyond the fact that bullying in the form of insulting messages have led to kids committing suicide, cyberbullying is far more broad in its scope” (Fioriello).

To reduce cyberbullying, it is not enough to just help the victims. Bullies need to get educated too because in many cases bullies might not know the severity of the situation or they might be doing it to fit in with their peers or they might be facing mental health issues. So, parents and teachers need to take measures to make sure that their child or student is not bullying others. Sherri Gordon, a professional life coach, writing for [verywell.com](https://www.verywell.com) says, “To prevent your kids from cyberbullying others, be sure you talk to them about the consequences of bullying others. Aside from the ramifications for online bullying, make sure they know how cyberbullying makes others feel” (Gordon).

Reaching out to psychologists can be very useful as mental health problems are common among victims and in some cases, bullies. According to Abramson writing for APA, “Psychologists—thanks to their expertise in child and teen development, communication, relationships, and mental health—can also make important contributions in preventing cyberbullying” (Abramson).

Anyone, regardless of age, gender, color, or sexuality, can be a victim of cyberbullying. If you are not the one being bullied, it could be a friend or family member, and the bully could be someone you know. Everyone is at risk of being cyberbullied, therefore learning about cyberbullying and effective countermeasures is critical. The solutions mentioned above can be effective in solving the problem if they are followed seriously.

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